

LOOKS.TASTES.SENSATIONS

Ye gods, even Zeus would hate these madding hordes

Tourist ears are tuned for the echoes of an ancient civilisation. Instead, voices from Sydney and scooter shrieks fill the air. KEITH DUNSTAN found Greeks love noise.

OUR FIRST glimpse of the Parthenon was through the early morning fog. There it was — ethereal, a mystic God-like creation. That was morning. Now the sun is going down and we are seeing it in a warm pink glow. One's eyes move lovingly over the perfection of its symmetry, the most marvellous of man's timeless creations.

Oh, you can't help but think how decent it was of the ancient Greeks to provide this timeless tourist asset. We are just part of the landing party that makes early invasions of Romans, Phoenicians, Huns and Turks seem puny affairs.

Now we are armies of French, Germans, Swedes, English, Australians and Americans. Good grief, is there an American left in the US now?

But please sympathise — I was trying to buy a screwdriver. So I turned to my guide book, which had a list of handy phrases for anywhere in Europe. With perfect fluency I asked the girl in the hardware store for a small screwdriver. She looked back, large brown eyes utterly puzzled. Dammit, I had picked the wrong column and was asking for it in Spanish instead of Greek.

This morning we were struggling to find our way to Syntagma Square. So we asked an interesting blonde.

"Do you speak English?"

"Sure do. Learnt it back home in Sandringham, Australia." She didn't know where she was either.

My wife said: "Next time we will ask someone who is indisputably and obviously Greek." Bravely she chose a gentleman in a pale beige double-breasted suit. He had a black moustache, a bronze skin and he could have descended from Zeus himself. She asked:

"Please, could you tell us the way to ..."

"I am very, very sorry, I am from Jerusalem. I have been here three days."

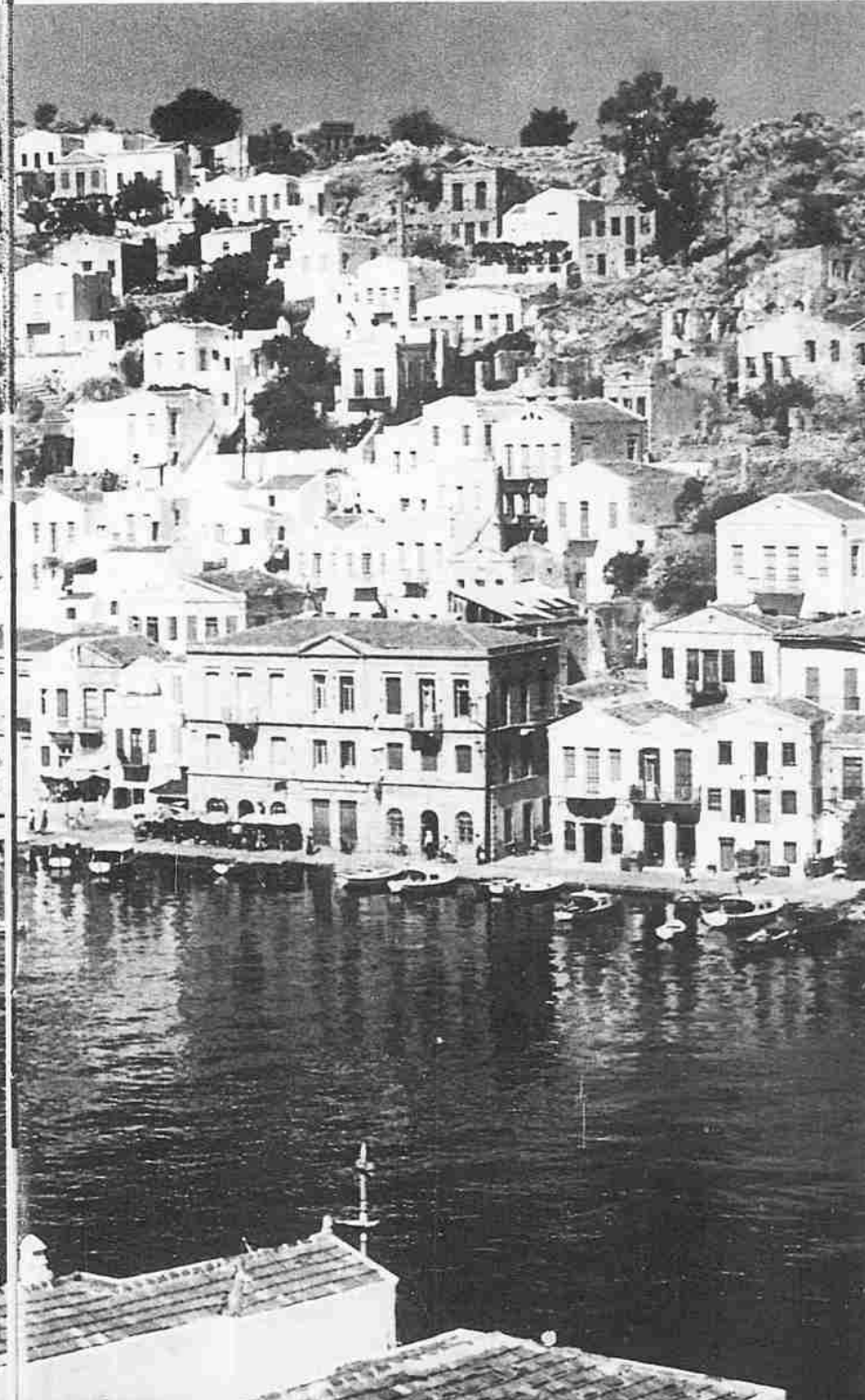
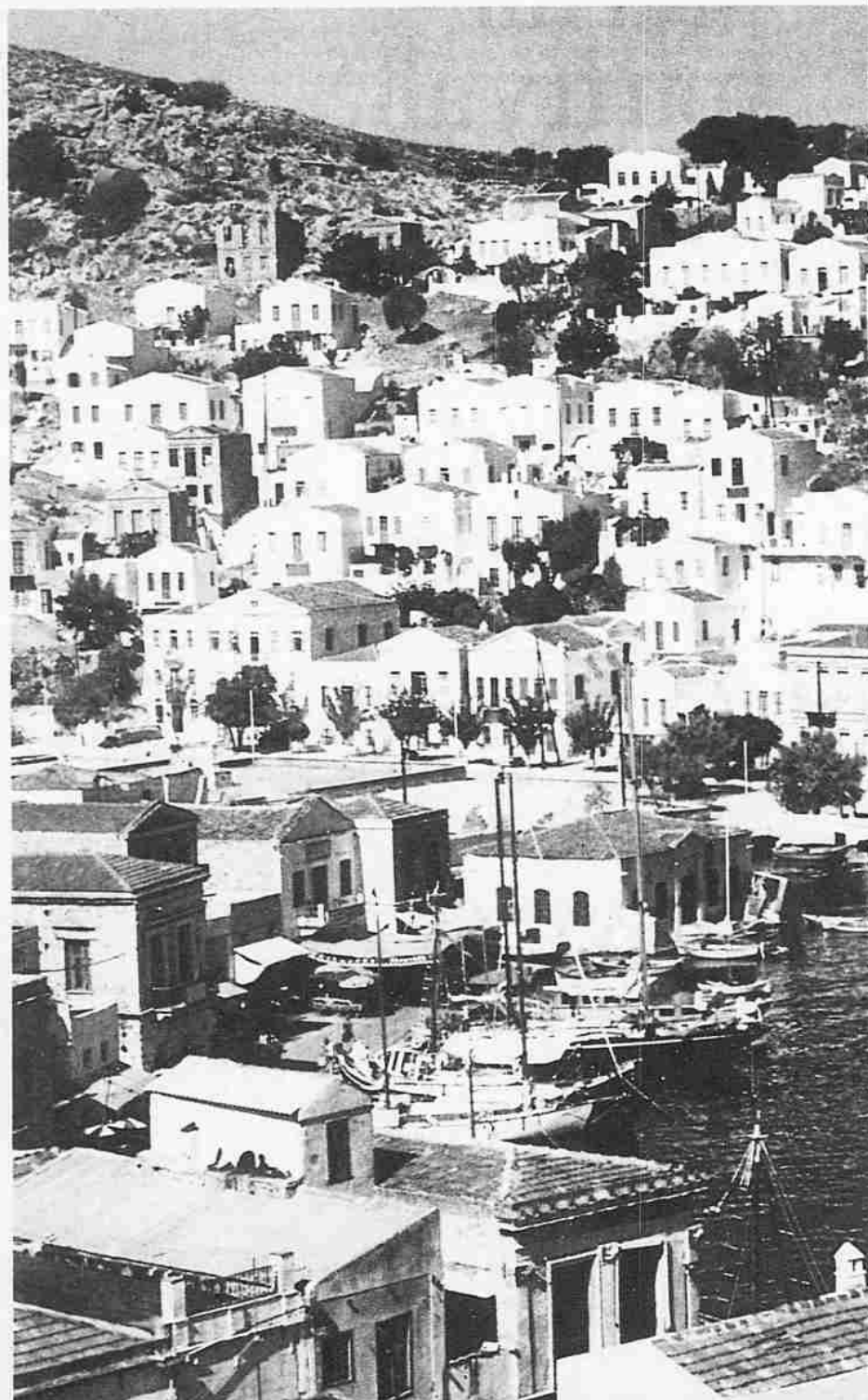
It is Sunday and we are in the Plaka, one of the finest tourist traps of all Europe, a thousand little tavernas and exquisite little shops. Unquestionably somewhere in Athens there is a monster factory, bigger than General Motors. It has a production line that turns out copies of every era of classical statuary ... Hercules, Zeus, Aphrodite, Diana, warriors, 5th century BC plates, urns, friezes — not a god, minotaur, centaur or mythological creature unturned.

One lifts one's ears to take in the

prevailing tones of the ancient cradle of civilisation. It is rich and eloquent — the voices of Hoboken, New Jersey; Birmingham, Alabama; Miami, Florida; San Jose, California; Toledo, Ohio; Memphis, Tennessee.

And hark, I hear music. Could it be a bouzouki, fiercely strummed Greek music to set one's blood afire?

Not actually. It is an unshaven youth with a large guitar. He has hair in a plait half way down his back. He is wearing a strange ankle-length blanket, probably borrowed from a guru in an ashram. He is doing a busker job, strumming away, his voice a high-pitched whine, and he is desperately trying to be Bob Dylan. I bet



Left, the harbour at Symi; top, luggage by the truck-load at Rhodes; above, take-aways tourist style for the Rhodes hordes

he's a refugee from Santa Monica, California.

The Plaka is just a few blocks southwest of Syntagma Square and it extends to the base of the Acropolis. It looks ancient. Nothing has been painted for centuries. Everything is satisfactorily crumbling and peeling. The streets are wide enough to be used by a motor bike and every building has a couple of little Antony and Cleopatra balconies.

We find an enchanting taverna. Find it — my God, it is impossible to avoid an enchanting taverna. The tavernas are in an unending line with the proprietors urging you to come in. Mercifully, at least the Greeks have remained Greeks. I understand there is a McDonald's in the Champs Elysees. Not here. No McDonald's, no Pizza Hut, no Red Rooster, no Wendy's and, thank all dozen of the great Greek gods, not a single Colonel Sanders.

It was Lawrence Durrell who inspired us to go to Greece. He could run on for page after page about the mystic calm of those Greek islands, the violet blue of the Aegean and the extraordinary ethereal light which would finally get to your soul.

So off we go to Rhodes. Absolutely essential journey. This is the island Zeus pulled out of the sea to appease Helios, ▽